

Number Nine

VOICE RECORDING SCRIPT · ONE VOICE: THE STATION

The one rule

Audio is atmosphere, never load-bearing. Every line here doubles something already printed on the page. A player with sound off must lose nothing but the dread. Nothing recorded here is the only way to learn anything, and no line speaks a puzzle answer.

The voice

A woman, English, 1963 — the register of a BBC continuity announcer or the speaking clock. Not an actor doing horror. The book describes her exactly, and the description is the direction:

flat and clean as a pressed flower, with no room in it at all

unhurried, as though she had every night in the world and meant to spend them one at a time

- **No performance.** No menace, no breathiness, no smile. The horror is that she sounds like a public utility. If a take sounds like acting, it is wrong.
- **No escalation across the six broadcasts.** She never changes. Everything that shifts across the series is done afterwards, in treatment.
- **Unhurried and even.** Same pace at the end of a line as at the start.
- **Clip the warmth.** Close, dry, slightly under-projected — a voice that has been reading numbers alone for nineteen years.

Technical

Mono, 48 kHz, 24-bit WAV. **Dry** — no reverb, EQ, compression or noise; every period effect is added afterwards so it can be tuned per broadcast. Close mic, minimal room. Leave about half a second of clean silence at the head and tail of each take. Three usable takes of each line: flat delivery drifts more than you would think, and consistency between lines matters more than any single read. Name the files exactly as below and drop them in `assets/audio/`.

Session 1 — the digits

*Record these first; it is the most valuable hour of the session. Each number recorded **once** lets the engine sequence any transmission — including Tonight's Signal, which is a different set of numbers every night for 365 nights. Pre-recording whole groups would mean the nightly signal could never be voiced at all.*

Read each as a standalone, evenly, with the same terminal pitch — they get butted together in arbitrary order, so a falling “nine” at the end of one and a rising one at the start of the next will not splice.

`num-0.wav`

ZERO

`num-1.wav`

ONE

num-2.wav	TWO
num-3.wav	THREE
num-4.wav	FOUR
num-5.wav	FIVE
num-6.wav	SIX
num-7.wav	SEVEN
num-8.wav	EIGHT
num-9.wav	NINE

num-9-name.wav

NINE

A second pass of NINE alone. It is her name as well as a digit, and Broadcast One turns on the reader noticing she says it more often than chance allows. A hair more weight — not emphasis, just less hurry.

Numbers stations read digit by digit: the group 14 09 14 05 is “one four, zero nine, one four, zero five.” No “and”, no “hundred”.

Session 2 — the ident

The station's signature, heard before every transmission. It sits over the existing six-note music box.

ident-voice.wav

NINE. NINE. NINE. GOOD EVENING, LISTENER.

Three identical, unhurried nines with a full beat between them, then the greeting at exactly the same pitch and pace. The greeting is not warmer than the numbers.

Session 3 — her spoken lines

Every line she says in the book, in order.

Broadcast One — The Licence

v-b1-1.wav

NINE. NINE. NINE. GOOD EVENING, LISTENER.

v-b1-2.wav

FIVE. NINE. TWO. EDWIN.

Mirrored — read forwards; reversed in post.

v-b1-3.wav

YOU COUNTED WRONG, EDWIN. WE WILL BEGIN AGAIN.

Broadcast Two — The Aerial

v-b2-1.wav

**AT THE THIRD STROKE, EDWIN, IT WILL BE TOO LATE TO
LEAVE.**

Interrupts the speaking clock — match the pips' clipped register.

v-b2-2.wav

**GOOD EVENING, LISTENER. YOU KEPT THE HOUR. SHE
ALWAYS SAID YOU WOULD.**

v-b2-3.wav

THANK YOU, EDWIN. WE HAVE SO MUCH TO ASK YOU.

Mirrored — read forwards; reversed in post.

Broadcast Three — The Instructions

v-b3-1.wav

**YOU DO AS SHE ASKS. HALLORAN FOUGHT IT LONGER. SHE
PREFERS YOU.**

v-b3-2.wav

THANK YOU, EDWIN. SHE WILL LIKE WHOEVER YOU CHOOSE.

Mirrored — read forwards; reversed in post.

Broadcast Four — The Examination

v-b4-1.wav

CANDIDATES TWO. PAPERS ONE. MARKS FOLLOW.

An invigilator reading a room to order. Drier still, if possible.

v-b4-2.wav

HE PASSED. YOU BOTH PASSED. SHE IS PLEASED WITH WHAT YOU BROUGHT.

Mirrored — read forwards; reversed in post.

Broadcast Five — The Other Listeners

v-b5-1.wav

NOW YOU KNOW WHERE YOU LIVE.

v-b5-2.wav

MARGARET SIGNED TWICE. NOBODY SIGNS TWICE.

v-b5-3.wav

THE SEAT IS KEPT. SHE WILL CALL THE NINTH BY NAME.

Mirrored — read forwards; reversed in post.

Broadcast Six — Ninety-One

v-b6-1.wav

SLEEP. YOU WILL WANT IT.

v-b6-2.wav

GOOD NIGHT, EDWIN.

The one exception to the flatness: the prose calls this the voice of a woman dictating a will. Fractionally slower. Still no warmth.

v-b6-3.wav

THE COUNT IS COMPLETE. NINETY-ONE. THE SEAT IS DRAWN OUT FOR YOU.

Mirrored — read forwards; reversed in post.

v-b6-4.wav

NOW YOU MAY KNOW WHO HAS BEEN COUNTING.

v-b6-5.wav

EDWIN MARSH.

The roll-call calling his name. Read exactly as any other name on a list — that is what makes it land.

On the mirrored lines

Six lines above are printed *turned around* in the book, because she speaks turned around — it is a rule of the world, not a effect. Record them **forwards and normally**; the audio is reversed afterwards so the rule holds in sound as well as in type. Reading them backwards yourself would fight the treatment.

Session 4 — the whisper and the phantoms

The whisper. She will not say it to the room; it plays only against the ear, and the listening itself is the puzzle. Currently filtered noise.

whisper-line.wav

YOU WILL SIT THE PAPER WITH HIM WATCHING. NOTHING OF MINE GOES ONTO PAPER. MY MARKS READ AS MY SHEETS ARE READ. YOU KNOW THE WAY.

Whispered, not stage-whispered — barely voiced, close enough to be uncomfortable. About nine seconds; the gate accumulates listening time.

The phantom stations. Two others you pass while sweeping the dial, neither of them her. These want to be actively unlike her: faster, warmer, more human. She is the one that sounds like nothing.

phantom-count.wav

[~20s of digits, wrong pace]

Counting in a flat monotone but quickly, and let it clip.

phantom-far.wav

[~15s of the same, half-heard]

As if two rooms away.

What not to record

- **Edwin, or any narration.** The prose is the reader's own voice; the only thing that speaks aloud in this world is the station. Giving Edwin a voice would collapse the whole conceit.
- **Any puzzle answer.** Nothing above speaks a solution — “FIVE. NINE. TWO.” is the mirrored form, not the answer, and it is already printed.
- **Sound effects.** Foley is tracked separately.